

IRS has teamed up with a number of private companies that provide online forms you can use to file your returns electronically.

You can also choose to use the forms available on sites like H&R Block's TaxCut (www.taxcut.com) or Intuit's TurboTax (www.turbotax.com). Costs for using any of these options range from about \$19.95 to \$59.99 per return.

You may have another possibility. If your adjusted gross income was \$54,000 or less in 2009, the IRS's Free File program allows you to fill out and e-file your tax forms online at no cost. Go to www.irs.gov and search for "Free File."

If you e-file and discover that you owe the IRS money, you'll be able to pay it electronically or by check or money order. If the IRS owes you a refund, you can click a box indicating you want the money deposited directly in your checking or savings account, and it will appear there within about a week of e-filing. With paper tax returns, refunds can take up to eight weeks.

Although this chapter deals mostly with federal taxes, don't forget that your state and local taxes are also due on April 15.

Who Has to File a Tax Return?

If you're single and your parents are not claiming you as a dependent on their tax return, you must file a tax return as long as your gross income is \$8,750 (as of 2009) or more. For married couples who file a joint return, the 2009 minimum income for filing is \$17,500.

If you're a full-time student and you're under 24, your parents can claim you as a dependent. But if your income exceeds certain limitations you might still have to file. The rules for these limits can be found at the IRS website (www.irs.gov); search for Publication 17, *Your Federal Income Tax*. They're incredibly convoluted, so it would probably take longer for you to sort through them than to fill out a simple tax form. My advice: File a tax return, even if you're not entirely sure you need to. It can't hurt.

When Should You File?